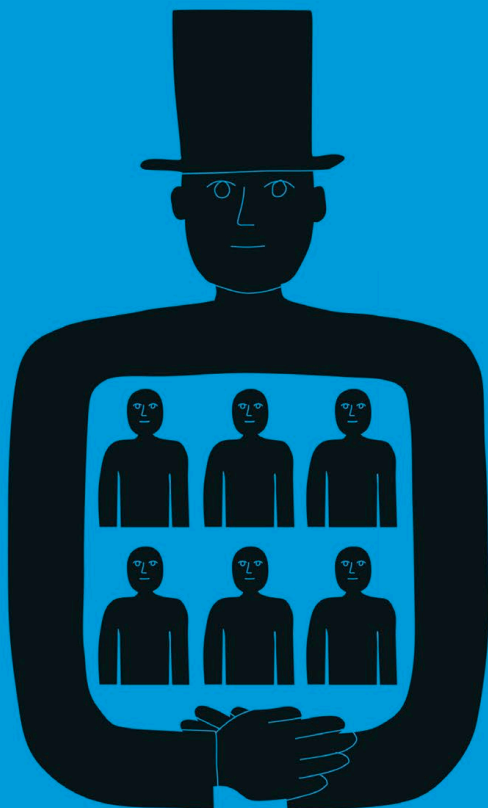


ALL GOVERNORS SHALL KEEP EVERY POOR PERSON

THE POOR LAWS (1535, 1601)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Social welfare

BEFORE

1351 The English Parliament's Statute of Labourers requires that everyone able to work must do so.

1388 The Statute of Cambridge differentiates between "sturdy" and "impotent" beggars.

1494 The Vagabonds and Beggars Act states that "vagabonds, idle, and suspected persons" should be punished.

AFTER

1662 The Act of Settlement allows for the exclusion of outsiders from a parish.

1696–1698 In Bristol, the Corporation of the Poor opens England's first two workhouses.

1834 The Poor Law Amendment Act introduces workhouses run by "unions" of parishes.

1948 The National Assistance Act abolishes the old Poor Law and ensures relief to all over age 16 and "without resource."

The 1601 English and Welsh Poor Law Act was one of the first attempts in the world to establish a national legal framework to deal with poverty. Building on various laws that had been enacted since the mid-14th century, it established the precedent that there must be laws for tackling the personal and wider economic outcomes of poverty and that the fate of paupers could not be left to chance and charity.